

Emotional Regulation

East County Transitional Living Center – Life Skills Class

Facilitator: Glenn Morgan

Part 1: Emotions Are Constructed, Not Automatic

Core Insight:

Emotions do not simply “happen” to you. Your brain predicts and constructs them.

Key Concepts

- **Your Brain Predicts:** It constantly asks, “What is this most like from my past?”
- **Same Sensation, Different Meaning:** A racing heart can mean anxiety or determination.
- **Emotions Are Built:** They are created from body sensations, context, memory, and interpretation.
- **You Are the Architect:** What you practice today becomes your brain’s prediction tomorrow.

Part 2: The 90-Second Rule

Stress chemicals released during anger last approximately 90 seconds in the body.

After that, continued anger is sustained by replaying the event and feeding the story. You are either letting the chemicals flush or keeping them alive through rumination.

Emotional Intelligence in Action

1. The Button-Pusher Myth

No one pushes your buttons. They reveal where your buttons already exist.

2. Anger Is Often Secondary

Anger frequently protects hurt, fear, rejection, or shame.

3. The Choice Point

Between trigger and response, there is a space. In that space lies freedom.

4. The Observer Self

Instead of “I am angry,” say, “I notice anger rising.” You are not your emotion. You are the observer.

5. The Story Stopper

You do not experience reality. You experience your interpretation of reality.

Practical Regulation Framework

1. Pause – 90 seconds.
2. Check the Body – Hungry, tired, dehydrated?
3. Identify the Real Emotion – What is underneath the anger?
4. Find the Choice Point – Who do I want to be right now?
5. Choose a Response – Not a reaction.

Group Discussion Activity (Final 10 Minutes)

Full Class Discussion: Emotional Responsibility in Real Life

As a group, discuss the following:

- Why do we prefer to believe emotions “just happen” to us?
- What is harder: controlling your behavior or taking responsibility for your emotional interpretation?
- When have you misread someone’s emotion or intention?
- What would change in your relationships if you used the 90-second rule consistently?
- Which concept today felt most challenging to accept, and why?

Goal: Increase awareness, not perfection. The purpose of this discussion is to practice recognizing the choice point in real scenarios.

Closing Challenge

For the next 7 days, choose ONE technique:

- 90-Second Rule
- Observer Self
- Story Stopper
- Choice Point Pause

Emotional mastery is built through repetition. You are not a remote control. You are the operator.